negotiate in good faith. This will yield a political system in which we are able to rise above partisan hatred and enter into bargains that make everyone better off.

The trust building that is required for this is hampered when policy measures are hatched in secrecy and suddenly unveiled upon the populace. The persons who get hurt feel that they were not treated fairly. This adversely affects the trust capital of the country, and holds back our emergence as a mature political system.

Give people time to change behaviour

Let us go back to the example of trade liberalization. So far, we have emphasized the presence of people who lose from the reform. But sheer fairness requires that they need to be able to plan for this ahead of time.

But the full impact upon the economy works through a series of adaptations. Some of the affected firms may choose to wind down their business or sell it. Others will choose to push up their productivity. Some firms that *use* goods that have lower tariffs will now see new opportunities to make things for the local or overseas market, as a consequence of lower prices. This may, in turn, kick off technological changes.

The full impact of a policy measure plays out in reshaping the work of the private sector. It is better for this work to commence as early as possible. For this reason, an open and consultative process works better.

If private persons have ample warning, their adaptations commence at an earlier date. Through this, the lags of the policy process are reduced. The gains for the economy are obtained in a shorter period.

It is easy to deride ‘paralysis through analysis’. For many people who are not instinctively comfortable with intellectual discourse, the slow process of public debates and government committees seems like a waste of time. Reaching out to critics is tactically costly as this increases the say that critics have in stalling or subverting a reform. The authoritarian impulse, to favour action over talk, is fashionable.